Flourish
LEGAL WELL-BEING

The Harm Reduction Model:
A Flexible Approach to Substance Use

The harm reduction model offers an inclusive, individualized approach to substance use. It focuses on reducing risks and meeting people where they are.

Key Concepts of Harm Reduction

Flexible Goals Beyond Abstinence

Your goals can range from safer use, to reduced use, to total abstinence, or even just wanting to understand your use better.

Curiosity Over Judgment

This approach begins with curiosity. By exploring personal patterns and motivations, you can better understand your relationship with substances and make informed choices.

Self-Compassion as a Foundation

Harm reduction sees setbacks as learning opportunities, not failures. It emphasizes patience and self-compassion.

Compatibility with Traditional Models

Harm reduction does not replace "abstinence-only" models like AA, which remain valuable resources. It complements them, offering additional options.

The Language Shift

- Harm reduction moves away from terms like "clean" or "addict," focusing on language that emphasizes personal autonomy and reduces stigma.

Evidence of Success

- Countries adopting comprehensive harm reduction approaches, like Portugal and Switzerland, have shown positive outcomes.
- Some U.S. cities and states have begun implementing similar programs on a more localized level.